

His-Story
History • Stories • A Greater You

THE EMPTY THRONE



A HISTORICAL FICTION STORY

CONTENTS

CHAPTER ONE

THE THRONE THAT WAITED

CHAPTER TWO

THE KING'S LAST NIGHT

CHAPTER THREE

THE MARK ON THE WALL

CHAPTER 4

A Warning from Atine

CHAPTER 5

The Forgotten Record

CHAPTER 6

The Stranger Arrives

CHAPTER 7

The Nobleman's Secret

CHAPTER 8

Beneath the Palace

CHAPTER 9

The Truth About the King

CHAPTER 10

Betrayal

CHAPTER 11

The Return

CHAPTER 12

The Throne

LIFE LESSONS

QUESTIONS ABOUT THE STORY

PROVERBS & IDIOMS

AUTHOR'S NOTE

CHAPTER ONE

THE THRONE THAT WAITED

Before the sun rose over Amachara Kingdom, the royal drums were already speaking.

Their deep rhythm travelled through the sleeping streets, across the farms, and beyond the walls of the ancient palace. It was the sound that announced an important day.

The Festival of Ancestors had begun.

By sunrise, the kingdom was alive.

Women carried baskets of food toward the palace courtyard. Traders arranged their finest goods beneath colourful canopies. Children chased one another between the crowds while elders gathered beneath the great iroko trees, telling stories of kings who had ruled Amachara long before anyone could remember.

At the centre of everything stood the royal palace.

It was an enormous structure of carved wood and red earth, its walls decorated with symbols representing the history of the kingdom.

But inside the palace was something that had puzzled generations.

A throne.

An empty throne.

It stood at the far end of the Great Hall on a raised platform. Its dark wood had been polished until it shone, and intricate carvings covered its arms and back.

Beside it rested a golden crown.

No one had worn it for many years.

Samson stood several steps away, staring at the throne.

He had been there for almost ten minutes.

"Are you planning to sit on it?"

Samson turned.

His best friend, Eze, was leaning against one of the pillars with his arms folded.

Samson smiled.

"Maybe."

Eze laughed.

"You would probably be thrown out before you even touched it."

Samson looked back at the throne.

"Do you ever wonder why it's still empty?"

Eze's smile disappeared.

"Everyone knows why."

"Do they?"

Eze walked closer.

"King Ayine disappeared."

"I know."

"He never returned."

"I know that too."

"Then what else is there to wonder about?"

Samson remained silent.

For years, the people of Amachara had been told the same story.

King Ayine had left the kingdom on a journey.

He had never returned.

Search parties had been sent into the forests and across neighbouring lands. Nothing had been found.

No body.

No royal belongings.

No final message.

Nothing.

Eventually, the elders announced that the king must have died.

The people mourned.

But they never buried him.

And somehow, the throne remained empty.

Samson had always found that strange.

A sudden sound interrupted his thoughts.

Tap.

He looked down.

Something had fallen from beneath the throne.

A small piece of wood.

Samson bent down and picked it up.

It was not ordinary wood.

A symbol had been carved into it.

An eye surrounded by three curved lines.

Samson turned it over in his hand.

"Eze."

"What?"

"Have you seen this before?"

Eze examined it.

"No."

Samson looked toward the throne.

"Someone carved it."

"Probably."

"Recently?"

Eze shrugged.

"How should I know?"

Samson was about to answer when footsteps echoed across the hall.

They turned.

An elderly man entered.

It was Atiewin, the former royal adviser.

Although he was old, he still carried himself with authority. He had served King Ayine before the king disappeared, and people often said that Atiewin knew more about the old palace than anyone alive.

His eyes fell immediately on the piece of wood in Samson's hand.

He stopped.

For a moment, nobody spoke.

Then Atiewin walked toward them.

"Where did you get that?"

Samson held it out.

"It fell from beneath the throne."

Atiewin did not take it.

Instead, he stared at the symbol.

His face had changed.

"What is it?" Samson asked.

"Nothing."

"Then why are you worried?"

"I am not worried."

"You look worried."

Atiewin finally looked at Samson.

"Young man, there are questions that bring knowledge, and there are questions that bring trouble."

Samson frowned.

"Which kind is this?"

Atiewin's eyes moved toward the empty throne.

"The second kind."

He turned and walked away.

Samson watched him disappear through the doorway.

Eze whispered, "I told you."

"Told me what?"

"That asking questions would get you into trouble."

Samson looked down at the symbol again.

For some reason, he felt certain that Atiewin had lied.

And that made the small piece of wood more important than ever.

That evening, the festival continued long after sunset.

The drums grew louder.

Fires burned in the palace courtyard.

People danced and sang while elders performed the traditional ceremonies.

But Samson could not enjoy the celebration.

He kept thinking about the symbol.

When the palace finally became quiet, he returned to the Great Hall.

Moonlight entered through the high windows.

The throne stood alone.

Samson approached it.

He knelt and examined the floor.

Nothing.

He ran his fingers beneath the wooden platform.

Nothing.

Then he noticed something.

A thin line ran across one of the floorboards.

He pressed it.

Click.

Samson froze.

The floorboard moved slightly.

His heart began beating faster.

He looked toward the doorway.

Nobody was there.

He slowly lifted the board.

Beneath it was a narrow space.

Inside lay an old piece of cloth.

Samson pulled it out.

There was a symbol embroidered onto it.

The same symbol.

But this time, there was something else.

A single word had been stitched beneath it.

Samson held the cloth closer to the moonlight.

He read the word.

REMEMBER.

A cold feeling passed through him.

Then he heard footsteps behind him.

Someone was standing in the darkness.

Samson turned.

But there was no one there.

Only the empty throne.

And for the first time in years, Samson began to wonder whether King Ayine's disappearance had really been the end of the story.

Perhaps it had only been the beginning.

CHAPTER TWO

THE KING'S LAST NIGHT

Samson barely slept.

The word remained in his mind long after he had returned to his room.

REMEMBER.

Who had hidden the cloth beneath the throne?

Why had they carved the strange symbol?

And why had Atiewin looked frightened when he saw it?

Most importantly, what did it have to do with King Ayine?

At first light, Samson left his room and went looking for Owusu.

His older sibling was sitting beneath a mango tree near the eastern wall of the palace, reading an old book.

"You are awake early," Owusu said without looking up.

"I couldn't sleep."

"Why?"

Samson sat beside him.

"I found something beneath the throne."

That got Owusu's attention.

He closed the book.

"What did you find?"

Samson showed him the cloth.

Owusu stared at the embroidered symbol.

His expression slowly changed.

"Where did you get this?"

"Under the throne."

Owusu looked around before lowering his voice.

"Who else knows?"

"Atiewin saw the symbol."

"And?"

"He wouldn't explain it."

Owusu was silent.

Samson watched him carefully.

"You know something."

"I know what everyone knows."

"No. You know more."

Owusu sighed.

"When you were younger, I thought you would eventually stop asking questions."

"I haven't."

"I noticed."

Samson leaned closer.

"Tell me about the night King Ayine disappeared."

Owusu looked toward the palace.

"Why?"

"Because I don't believe the story."

"The story is that the king left Amachara and never returned."

"That isn't an explanation."

"It is the only explanation the council gave us."

"Then what really happened?"

Owusu hesitated.

Finally, he spoke.

"The night before the king disappeared, there was an argument."

"Between whom?"

"I don't know."

"Who told you?"

"Father."

Samson stared at him.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"Because Father made me promise."

"Promise what?"

"Never to repeat what I heard."

Samson stood.

"Owusu, this is about our kingdom."

"I know."

"And if someone lied about the king—"

"Lower your voice."

Samson stopped.

Owusu continued.

"After the argument, King Ayine ordered the palace guards to leave him alone."

"Was Atiewin there?"

"Yes."

"What about Obinna?"

Owusu looked at him.

"I don't know."

Samson remembered the warning from the previous day.

Some doors are better left closed.

He wondered what Atiewin was so afraid of.

Later that morning, Samson found Chinedu in the royal archives.

The room was filled with shelves of old records. Dust floated through shafts of sunlight that entered through the narrow windows.

Chinedu was carefully examining a collection of ancient documents.

"You came at the right time," he said.

"For what?"

"I found something interesting."

Samson showed him the cloth.

Chinedu immediately became serious.

"Where did you get that?"

"Under the throne."

Chinedu reached for it but stopped before touching it.

"I've seen this symbol."

"Where?"

"In a royal manuscript."

"Show me."

Chinedu walked to the far end of the room and pulled out a large, worn book.

He opened it carefully.

Several pages had drawings of ancient symbols.

There it was.

The same eye surrounded by three curved lines.

Samson's heart began beating faster.

"What does it mean?"

Chinedu read the faded writing beneath it.

"Memory."

"Memory?"

"That's what the old text says."

Samson pointed to the symbol.

"Was it connected to the royal family?"

Chinedu nodded.

"Apparently."

"Apparently?"

"The records are incomplete."

"Why?"

"Some pages are missing."

Samson frowned.

"Who removed them?"

"I don't know."

Before they could continue, the sound of footsteps came from outside.

Chinedu quickly closed the book.

A moment later, Atiewin entered.

He looked at Samson.

Then at the book.

Then at the cloth.

His face became expressionless.

"Where did you find that?"

Samson answered carefully.

"Under the throne."

Atiewin's voice became quieter.

"You should put it back."

"Why?"

"Because it does not belong to you."

"It belongs to the kingdom."

Atiewin stepped closer.

"You don't understand what you are touching."

"Then explain it to me."

The old adviser stared at him for several seconds.

Then he said something that Samson would remember for the rest of his life.

"The night King Ayine disappeared, he was searching for that symbol."

Samson froze.

Atiewin turned toward the door.

"Wait!"

The old man stopped.

"What was he searching for?"

Atiewin did not turn around.

"The truth."

Then he walked away.

That night, Samson returned to the Great Hall.

The festival decorations were still hanging from the walls, but the palace was silent.

He stood before the empty throne.

For years, everyone had treated it as a symbol of loss.

Now Samson wondered if it was also a warning.

He crouched and examined the place where he had found the cloth.

There was something else beneath the floorboard.

A small metal object.

He pulled it out.

It was a key.

Old.

Blackened with age.

And attached to it was a tiny piece of parchment.

Samson unfolded it.

Only one sentence had been written.

When the throne is empty, look beneath the crown.

Samson slowly looked at the golden crown resting beside the throne.

Then he heard the palace doors close somewhere behind him.

He turned.

A shadow moved across the corridor.

"Who's there?"

No answer.

Samson took a step forward.

The shadow disappeared.

He looked back at the crown.

Something told him that the next clue was closer than he thought.

Much closer.

And somewhere in the darkness of Amachara, someone else was watching him search.

CHAPTER THREE

THE MARK ON THE WALL

The following morning, Samson arrived at the throne room before anyone else.

He carried the old key in his pocket.

He had spent most of the night wondering about the message.

When the throne is empty, look beneath the crown.

The golden crown sat inside a glass case beside the throne.

Samson examined it carefully.

There was nothing unusual about it.

He checked the stand.

Nothing.

He looked beneath the case.

Nothing.

Then he noticed something.

The crown was not sitting directly on the bottom of the case.

There was a narrow space beneath its wooden stand.

Samson carefully lifted the stand.

A small compartment had been carved into the wood.

Inside was a folded piece of parchment.

He opened it.

There was no writing.

Only the same symbol.

The eye.

The three curved lines.

And beneath it was a drawing of the palace.

Samson stared at the drawing.

A small mark had been placed on the western side of the building.

He knew that part of the palace.

It had been abandoned for years.

He folded the parchment and placed it in his pocket.

"You're becoming very good at finding things."

Samson spun around.

Eze stood in the doorway.

"You scared me."

"I've been calling you."

Samson showed him the parchment.

Eze studied it.

"Where did you get this?"

"Under the crown."

Eze raised an eyebrow.

"So the message was real."

Samson nodded.

"There's a mark on the western wing."

Eze sighed.

"I already know where this is going."

"Then come with me."

"I knew it."

The western wing of the palace had not been used for many years.

The doors were covered with dust, and weeds had grown around the outer walls.

Samson pushed the door open.

It groaned.

Inside, the air was cold.

Old furniture stood beneath white sheets.

Paint had peeled from the walls.

Eze looked around.

"If something jumps out, I'm blaming you."

"Nothing is going to jump out."

A loud noise came from upstairs.

Eze nearly jumped.

Samson laughed.

"Nothing?"

"That was probably a bird."

They continued.

At the end of a narrow corridor, Samson found the mark from the parchment.

It was carved into the wall.

The same symbol.

But this one was different.

There was a small hole in its centre.

Samson took out the key.

It fitted perfectly.

He turned it.

Click.

A section of the wall moved.

Behind it was a narrow wooden box.

Samson pulled it out.

Inside were several old documents.

Eze leaned over his shoulder.

"What do they say?"

Samson opened the first.

It was a list of names.

The second contained dates.

The third was badly damaged.

Then Samson found something that made him stop.

A royal seal.

King Ayine's seal.

And beneath it was a short note.

Samson read it aloud.

"If these records are found, the person who finds them must understand one thing: the danger is not outside the palace."

Eze looked at him.

"What does that mean?"

Samson shook his head.

"I don't know."

A sound came from behind them.

They turned.

Nobody was there.

Then a voice spoke from the corridor.

"Perhaps you should stop looking."

Samson froze.

A figure stepped into the doorway.

It was Obinna.

He stood with his hands behind his back, looking calm.

"What are you doing here?" Samson asked.

Obinna glanced at the box.

"I could ask you the same question."

"We found these records."

"I can see that."

"Why are you following us?"

Obinna smiled.

"I am not following you."

"Then why are you here?"

He looked at the symbol on the wall.

"Because there are things in this palace that should remain forgotten."

Samson stepped forward.

"Why?"

Obinna's smile disappeared.

"Because not every truth brings peace."

Eze whispered, "Let's go."

Samson refused to move.

"What do you know about King Ayine?"

Obinna's face became hard.

"You should be careful with that name."

"Why?"

"Because the dead cannot defend themselves."

Samson stared at him.

"Are you saying King Ayine is dead?"

Obinna said nothing.

Then he turned and walked away.

Samson looked down at the royal seal in his hand.

For the first time, he wondered whether Obinna had been warning him—
or threatening him.

That afternoon, Samson took the documents to Chinedu.

The young historian examined them carefully.

"This seal is genuine."

"How do you know?"

"I have studied the royal records for years."

Chinedu turned another page.

Then he stopped.

"Samson."

"What?"

"Look at this."

He pointed to a list of names.

One name had been crossed out.

Obinna.

Samson's eyes widened.

"What does that mean?"

"I don't know."

Chinedu turned the page.

There was another name.

Atiewin.

And beneath it was a sentence:

THE KEEPERS MUST NEVER TRUST ONE ANOTHER.

Samson felt a chill.

"Who were the Keepers?"

Chinedu looked at him.

"I think we're about to find out."

Outside the archive, unseen by them, someone stood listening.

And in that person's hand was another piece of the same ancient symbol.

CHAPTER 4

A Warning from Atine

The sun had barely risen when Samson left the palace.

The streets of Amachara were beginning to wake. Women swept the compounds in slow, steady movements. Smoke curled upward from cooking fires, carrying the smell of roasted plantain and warm porridge through the morning air. Somewhere in the distance, a blacksmith struck his hammer against metal.

Normally, Samson loved mornings like this.

Today, he barely noticed them.

His mind was still inside the abandoned western wing.

THE KEEPERS MUST NEVER TRUST ONE ANOTHER.

The words followed him like a shadow.

He had spent most of the night wondering about them.

Who were the Keepers?

Why had King Ayine written those words?

And why had Obinna reacted so strongly when Samson mentioned the king?

There was only one person Samson believed might help him.

His grandmother, Atine.

Atine lived in a quiet compound at the edge of the royal grounds. She was one of the oldest people in Amachara and had lived through the reigns of two kings before Ayine. People often came to her for advice,

especially when they needed to understand something that could not be found in ordinary records.

When Samson arrived, she was sitting beneath an old tree, sorting dried leaves into a woven basket.

She looked up before he spoke.

“You have the face of someone carrying a heavy question,” she said.

Samson stopped.

“How did you know?”

Atine smiled.

“A person does not need to announce a storm when the clouds are already speaking.”

Samson sat beside her.

“Grandmother, I found something in the palace.”

Her hands became still.

“What did you find?”

Samson reached into his clothing and brought out the small piece of cloth bearing the strange symbol.

Atine stared at it.

For several seconds, she said nothing.

Then she slowly placed the leaves aside.

“Where did you get this?”

“Beneath the throne.”

Atine's expression changed.

“Who else knows?”

“Eze. Chinedu. Owusu knows some of it.”

“And Obinna?”

Samson hesitated.

“He knows I'm asking questions.”

Atine looked toward the palace in the distance.

“Then you must stop asking questions carelessly.”

“Why?”

“Because some truths are buried for a reason.”

Samson frowned.

“But that doesn't mean they should stay buried.”

Atine studied him.

“That is true.”

She sighed.

“But remember this, my son: when you dig up an old secret, you may also uncover the person who buried it.”

A cold feeling passed through Samson.

“You know something about the symbol.”

Atine did not answer immediately.

Instead, she picked up a small stick and drew three curved lines in the soil.

Then she drew an eye above them.

Samson stared.

“It is the same symbol.”

“Yes.”

“What does it mean?”

“Memory.”

Samson remembered Chinedu saying the same thing.

“The Keepers,” he said. “Were they connected to this?”

Atine looked at him sharply.

“Where did you hear that word?”

“From an old document.”

“Who showed it to you?”

“Chinedu.”

Atine nodded slowly.

“Then the old records are beginning to speak again.”

Samson leaned forward.

“Grandmother, who were the Keepers?”

Atine lowered her voice.

“They were not kings. They were not soldiers. They were people entrusted with something more dangerous than gold.”

“What?”

“The truth.”

Samson waited.

Atine continued.

“Long ago, Amachara learned a painful lesson. A kingdom can survive the loss of wealth. It can survive the loss of buildings. It can even survive the loss of a king.”

She pointed toward the palace.

“But if a kingdom loses the truth about its own past, it becomes easy for someone to control its future.”

Samson thought about the empty throne.

“So King Ayine was a Keeper?”

“No.”

Atine shook her head.

“He was something different.”

“What?”

“A king who discovered that someone had forgotten what the Keepers were protecting.”

Samson's heart began beating faster.

“Was that why he disappeared?”

Atine looked away.

“I don't know everything.”

“But you know something.”

“Yes.”

“Then please tell me.”

Atine was silent for a long moment.

Finally, she said, “Your grandfather once told me that King Ayine had become suspicious of people close to him.”

“Who?”

“I never learned all their names.”

“But you knew he was afraid?”

“I knew he was careful.”

She picked up a dry leaf and turned it between her fingers.

“Not long before he disappeared, Ayine came here.”

Samson stared at her.

“He came here?”

“Yes.”

“What did he say?”

Atine's eyes became distant, as if she were seeing another time.

“He asked me a strange question.”

“What question?”

“He asked, ‘If a king disappears, who benefits from his silence?’”

Samson felt a chill.

“What did you tell him?”

“I told him that the answer mattered more than the question.”

“And what did he say?”

Atine looked directly at Samson.

“He said, ‘Then I already know where to begin.’”

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Samson suddenly remembered Obinna's words.

Because the dead cannot defend themselves.

“Grandmother,” he said quietly, “do you think King Ayine was killed?”

Atine's expression hardened.

“I do not know.”

“But you don't believe he simply died.”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because your king was not a man who would walk into darkness without leaving someone a lamp.”

Samson frowned.

“What does that mean?”

“It means that if Ayine knew danger was coming, he would have prepared for it.”

Samson remembered the hidden documents.

The symbol.

The message.

The secret compartment.

Everything seemed connected.

“Then maybe he left clues.”

Atine nodded.

“Perhaps.”

“Maybe he expected someone to find them.”

“Perhaps.”

“Maybe he knew someone would eventually search for the truth.”

Atine looked at him sadly.

“That person may be you.”

Samson felt the weight of those words.

“But why me?”

“Because you are asking questions that others are afraid to ask.”

She leaned closer.

“Listen carefully, Samson. Courage is not the same as rushing into danger.”

“I understand.”

“No. You don't.”

Her voice was firm.

“If you continue, do not trust a person simply because they are old. Do not trust someone simply because they wear royal clothing. And do not trust someone merely because they claim to love the kingdom.”

Samson remembered the crossed-out names.

Obinna.

Atiewin.

His stomach tightened.

“What about Atiewin?”

Atine's eyes narrowed.

“What about him?”

“His name was in the records.”

Atine was quiet.

“Then you should be careful.”

“Do you think he betrayed Ayine?”

“I did not say that.”

“But you think he knows something.”

“I think many people know something.”

She looked toward the palace.

“And some have spent years praying that no one would ask.”

A breeze moved through the leaves above them.

Then Atine said something that Samson would remember for the rest of his life.

“When the root is rotten, the fruit cannot remain healthy.”

Samson repeated the words softly.

“What does that mean?”

“It means you cannot repair what is wrong by changing only what people can see.”

She touched the cloth bearing the symbol.

“The empty throne is what everyone sees.”

Her finger moved to the symbol.

“But the truth is beneath it.”

Samson suddenly understood.

The throne was not the real mystery.

The throne was only the door.

He stood.

“Grandmother, I have to go back.”

Atine immediately grabbed his wrist.

“Not alone.”

Samson looked at her.

“Why?”

“Because someone already knows you are searching.”

His eyes widened.

“How do you know?”

Atine released him slowly.

“I received a warning this morning.”

“What warning?”

She pointed toward the ground beside the tree.

Samson looked down.

At first, he saw nothing unusual.

Then he noticed a small object lying in the dust.

A piece of black wood.

Carved into it was the same symbol.

The eye.

The three curved lines.

And beneath it, one word:

STOP.

Samson's breath caught.

“When did you find this?”

“At sunrise.”

“Who left it?”

“I don't know.”

Samson bent down but did not touch it.

Atine's voice became almost a whisper.

“Now you understand why I warned you.”

He stared at the message.

Someone had followed him.

Someone knew about the symbol.

And someone wanted the search to end.

Samson slowly straightened.

For the first time, the mystery of King Ayine no longer felt like something buried in the past.

It felt alive.

And it was coming for them.

Atine looked at him.

“Samson.”

“Yes?”

“If you choose to continue, remember one thing.”

“What?”

She looked toward the empty throne visible beyond the trees.

“Truth may hide for many years.”

She paused.

“But it never forgets the way home.”

And somewhere inside the palace, a bell rang once.

Then stopped.

CHAPTER 5

The Forgotten Record

The bell rang again.

Once.

Then silence.

Samson remained beneath Atine's tree, staring toward the palace.

“That bell hasn't rung in years,” he said.

Atine's face had become serious.

“Then someone wants you to hear it.”

Samson looked back at the piece of black wood lying in the dust.

The warning was still there.

STOP.

But instead of frightening him into giving up, it raised another question.

Why would someone threaten him if there was nothing to discover?

He picked up the wooden piece carefully.

Atine watched him.

“Do not mistake a warning for an answer,” she said.

“I won't.”

“Good. Because the person who left that may be hoping you will become careless.”

Samson slipped the piece into his pocket.

“I need to find Chinedu.”

“Then find him.”

“And Eze.”

“Take someone you trust.”

Samson nodded.

As he turned to leave, Atine called him back.

“There is something else.”

Samson stopped.

“What?”

“Your grandfather once told me that the royal records were not all kept in the palace archives.”

“Where were the others kept?”

Atine looked toward the oldest part of the palace.

“Some records were hidden because they contained information that could not safely be placed in the public archives.”

“Where?”

“I don't know.”

Samson frowned.

“You said the records were hidden.”

“I said I knew they existed. I did not say I knew where they were.”

She smiled faintly.

“Sometimes an old woman knows when to keep a secret.”

Samson smiled.

“I suppose you do.”

“Go.”

By midday, Samson had found Eze and Chinedu.

The three boys sat inside a quiet corner of the palace library, surrounded by shelves of old books and rolled manuscripts.

Chinedu had been searching since early morning.

“I found something,” he said.

Samson immediately leaned closer.

“What?”

Chinedu placed an old book on the table.

Its leather cover was cracked, and several pages were missing.

“I found this behind a shelf that hasn't been moved in years.”

Eze raised an eyebrow.

“That sounds like exactly the kind of place where palace secrets like to hide.”

Chinedu ignored the joke.

“This isn't an ordinary history book.”

He opened it carefully.

The first pages described the founding of Amachara. There were records of ancient kings, wars, alliances, harvests and great ceremonies.

Then Chinedu stopped.

“Look here.”

Samson bent over the page.

A drawing of the palace had been made in faded ink.

But the palace was not as it looked today.

There was another structure beneath it.

A large chamber was drawn underneath the western side.

“What is that?” Eze asked.

“I don't know.”

Chinedu turned the page.

There was a short description beside the drawing.

THE HALL OF MEMORY.

Samson's eyes widened.

“The Hall of Memory.”

Chinedu nodded.

“I've heard the name before, but I thought it was a legend.”

“What does it say?”

Chinedu read silently for a moment.

Then his expression changed.

“It says the Hall was built to protect the most important records of the kingdom.”

“What records?” Samson asked.

“Royal agreements. Ancient laws. The names of kings. Secrets concerning the crown.”

Eze leaned closer.

“Secrets concerning the crown?”

Chinedu nodded.

“And there's more.”

He turned another page.

At the bottom was the same symbol.

The eye.

The three curved lines.

Underneath it was a sentence:

Only those who remember may enter.

Samson immediately thought of the message beneath the throne.

When the throne is empty, look beneath the crown.

Everything was beginning to connect.

“The Hall of Memory,” Samson whispered.

Chinedu continued searching through the book.

“There should be a record explaining how to enter.”

“Is it there?”

“No.”

He turned several pages.

Nothing.

Then he stopped.

“Someone removed it.”

Eze sighed.

“Of course they did.”

Samson stared at the torn edge of the page.

“How long ago?”

Chinedu examined the paper.

“Years ago. Maybe decades.”

Samson thought of Atine's warning.

The truth had been buried for a long time.

Perhaps someone had been making sure it stayed buried.

Suddenly, footsteps sounded outside the library.

All three boys froze.

The footsteps stopped at the door.

Nobody entered.

Eze whispered, “Did you hear that?”

Samson nodded.

Chinedu quickly closed the book.

The door opened.

Ngozi stepped inside.

She was one of the palace servants, and she looked unusually nervous.

“Samson,” she said quietly.

“What happened?”

She glanced toward the hallway.

“Someone has been asking about you.”

“Who?”

Ngozi hesitated.

“Obinna.”

Samson exchanged a glance with Eze.

“What did he ask?”

“He wanted to know where you had been.”

“And what did you tell him?”

“That I didn't know.”

Ngozi lowered her voice.

“But that isn't all.”

Samson stood.

“What else?”

“He asked whether you had been searching the old records.”

Silence filled the room.

Chinedu slowly looked at the book in front of him.

“How would he know?” Eze asked.

Ngozi shook her head.

“I don't know.”

Samson's thoughts raced.

Obinna knew he was searching.

Someone had left a warning at Atine's house.

Now Obinna was asking about the old records.

The search was no longer a secret.

“Did Obinna say anything else?” Samson asked.

Ngozi looked frightened.

“He said something strange.”

“What?”

“He said, ‘Some doors were locked for everyone's protection.’”

Samson's eyes narrowed.

“Did he mention the Hall of Memory?”

Ngozi shook her head.

“No.”

But her hesitation told Samson there was more.

“You're hiding something.”

Ngozi looked at the three boys.

“I heard two palace guards talking yesterday.”

“What did they say?”

“They said Obinna had ordered them to watch the western wing.”

Eze stood quickly.

“The western wing?”

“Yes.”

Samson remembered the hidden box.

The warning.

The symbol.

Someone had been there.

Perhaps they were not searching for the same thing.

Perhaps they were searching for the evidence before Samson could find it.

Chinedu opened the old book again.

“There is one more thing.”

He turned several pages until he found a faded paragraph.

“This mentions a record called the Crown Chronicle.”

“What is it?” Samson asked.

“I think it's the most important record in the kingdom.”

“Why?”

“Because it was supposed to record every major decision made by the kings.”

Chinedu pointed to the final line.

“It says the Crown Chronicle was last updated during King Ayine's reign.”

Samson's heart skipped.

“Where is it?”

Chinedu looked at him.

“That is the problem.”

He turned the page.

The rest had been torn away.

That evening, Samson returned to the western wing.

He did not tell anyone.

Not even Eze.

He walked carefully through the abandoned corridor until he reached the wall where they had found the hidden box.

The palace was quiet.

Too quiet.

Samson examined the wall again.

There had to be another clue.

He ran his fingers along the stones.

Nothing.

Then he noticed something.

One stone was slightly darker than the others.

He pressed it.

It moved.

Samson pulled it out.

Behind it was a narrow opening.

Inside lay a rolled piece of parchment.

His hands trembled as he opened it.

There was no name.

Only a few words:

THE CROWN CHRONICLE WAS NEVER DESTROYED.

Samson read the sentence again.

Then he saw the final line.

IT WAS MOVED TO THE PLACE WHERE THE KING COULD SEE
WITHOUT BEING SEEN.

Samson stared at the words.

“What does that mean?”

A sound came from behind him.

He turned sharply.

The corridor was empty.

Then a faint voice came from the darkness.

“You are looking in the wrong place.”

Samson froze.

“Who is there?”

No answer.

He stepped into the corridor.

“Show yourself!”

Still nothing.

Then he noticed something on the floor.

A small royal seal.

The same seal that belonged to King Ayine.

Samson picked it up.

It was warm.

As though someone had been holding it only moments earlier.

He looked down the corridor.

Someone had been here.

Someone who knew about the Crown Chronicle.

Someone who knew where it had been moved.

And perhaps...

someone who knew where the missing king was.

Samson closed his hand around the seal.

For the first time, he wondered whether they were still searching for King Ayine's past—

or whether the past was searching for them.

CHAPTER 6

The Stranger Arrives

The royal seal felt strangely heavy in Samson's hand.

He stood alone in the western corridor, listening to the silence.

Someone had been there.

Someone had spoken to him.

And whoever it was had known about the Crown Chronicle.

Samson looked down at the seal again.

The mark of King Ayine was still clear despite the years that had passed.

He slipped it into his pocket and hurried away from the western wing.

For the first time since beginning his search, he decided not to tell Eze or Chinedu everything.

Not yet.

There were too many people listening.

The following morning, Amachara woke to the sound of drums.

Samson stepped outside the palace and saw villagers gathering near the main gate.

A crowd had formed around a man who looked as though he had travelled a very long distance.

His clothes were dusty.

A small leather bag hung across his shoulder.

He carried a walking stick in one hand.

Most strangely, he wore an old bronze pendant around his neck.

Samson moved closer.

Eze was already there.

“Who is that?” Eze whispered.

“I don't know.”

An elderly villager called out, “Stranger! State your name and your business in Amachara.”

The man slowly raised his head.

“My name is Frimpong.”

A murmur passed through the crowd.

“And why have you come?”

Frimpong looked toward the palace.

“I have come because I carry a message.”

“For whom?”

Frimpong's eyes moved through the crowd.

Then they stopped on Samson.

“For the royal family.”

Samson's heart began to pound.

Eze noticed.

“Samson...”

“I know.”

Frimpong walked toward him.

The crowd parted.

When he reached Samson, he bowed.

“I was told to give this to you.”

He removed the bronze pendant from his neck.

Samson stared at it.

The symbol was carved into its surface.

The eye.

The three curved lines.

The same symbol.

“Where did you get this?” Samson asked.

Frimpong looked around.

“Not here.”

“Then where?”

“Some questions should be answered where walls cannot listen.”

Eze stepped forward.

“Who sent you?”

Frimpong looked directly at Samson.

“King Ayine.”

The crowd erupted.

Some people gasped.

Others began whispering.

One woman shouted, "That's impossible!"

Another said, "The king is dead!"

Frimpong remained calm.

"I did not say he is dead."

The crowd became silent.

Samson could barely breathe.

"Are you saying King Ayine is alive?"

Frimpong looked at him.

"I am saying that I was given a message by a man who called himself King Ayine."

Samson's mind raced.

"Where is he?"

"I cannot tell you."

"Why?"

"Because I was instructed to deliver the message first."

Samson looked at the pendant.

"What message?"

Frimpong reached into his bag.

He removed a folded piece of parchment.

The royal seal was pressed into the wax.

Samson recognized it immediately.

The same seal he had found in the western corridor.

His hands shook as he opened the message.

There were only a few lines.

THE CROWN IS NOT WHERE THEY THINK IT IS.

Samson read it twice.

Then he noticed another sentence.

TRUST THE ONE WHO REMEMBERS.

His heart raced.

He looked at Frimpong.

“What does this mean?”

Frimpong shook his head.

“I was told to give you the message, not explain it.”

“Why me?”

“Because your name was mentioned.”

“By the king?”

“Yes.”

Samson stared at him.

“What did he say?”

Frimpong's expression softened.

“He said, ‘When the boy begins asking questions, do not stop him. Guide him.’”

Samson felt a strange mixture of fear and determination.

King Ayine had expected this.

He had expected someone to find the clues.

He had expected Samson.

But before Samson could ask another question, a voice cut through the crowd.

“Enough.”

Everyone turned.

Obinna stood at the palace entrance.

His face was hard.

He walked slowly toward Frimpong.

“You claim to carry a message from a dead king?”

Frimpong did not answer.

Obinna stopped in front of him.

“Where is your proof?”

Frimpong held up the royal seal.

Obinna’s eyes immediately fell upon it.

For the briefest moment, something flashed across his face.

Fear.

Then it disappeared.

“That proves nothing,” Obinna said.

Samson noticed.

“You recognized it.”

Obinna turned toward him.

“I recognize the seal of the former king.”

“Then you know it is genuine.”

“I know nothing of the sort.”

Frimpong spoke calmly.

“The seal was given to me by King Ayine.”

Obinna's jaw tightened.

“Take this man away.”

Two guards stepped forward.

Samson immediately moved between them.

“Why?”

Obinna looked at him.

“Because he is disturbing the kingdom with a dangerous claim.”

“But what if he's telling the truth?”

“Then let the truth prove itself.”

Samson remembered Atine's warning.

Do not trust someone simply because they claim to love the kingdom.

Obinna turned to the guards.

“Arrest him.”

The guards grabbed Frimpong.

Suddenly Frimpong shouted, “Samson!”

Samson looked at him.

Frimpong's eyes were fixed on the bronze pendant.

He touched the symbol with two fingers.

Then he whispered something so quietly that only Samson could hear.

“The bell beneath the palace.”

Samson froze.

Before he could respond, the guards pulled Frimpong away.

That afternoon, Samson met Eze and Chinedu in the library.

“We need to talk,” Samson said.

Eze folded his arms.

“You mean about the stranger who claims King Ayine is alive?”

“Yes.”

Chinedu looked nervous.

“What did he give you?”

Samson placed the bronze pendant on the table.

Chinedu stared at it.

“The symbol.”

Samson nodded.

“And he gave me a message.”

“What did it say?”

Samson repeated the words.

The crown is not where they think it is.

Chinedu's eyes widened.

“And?”

“Trust the one who remembers.”

The room became silent.

Eze looked at Samson.

“Who remembers?”

Samson thought of Atine.

Then Chinedu.

Then Atiewin.

Then the mysterious records.

“We don't know.”

Chinedu picked up the pendant.

There was a tiny inscription on the back.

He wiped away the dust.

“Look.”

Three words were engraved there.

REMEMBER THE BELL.

Eze frowned.

“What bell?”

Samson immediately remembered Frimpong's whisper.

“The bell beneath the palace.”

Chinedu stood.

“There is no bell beneath the palace.”

“How do you know?”

“I have studied the palace records. Every bell tower and ceremonial bell is recorded.”

Samson looked at the pendant.

“Then why would he mention one?”

Chinedu had no answer.

Suddenly, they heard footsteps.

Someone was coming.

The three boys quickly hid the pendant.

The door opened.

Ngozi entered.

She looked frightened.

“Samson, you need to leave.”

“Why?”

“Obinna knows you spoke with Frimpong.”

Samson stood.

“What happened to him?”

Ngozi glanced toward the hallway.

“He was taken to the old guardhouse.”

“Is he safe?”

“I don't know.”

She lowered her voice.

“But there is something else.”

“What?”

“Frimpong was not the only stranger who entered Amachara.”

Samson stared at her.

“What do you mean?”

Ngozi looked toward the window.

“Someone else came before him.”

“Who?”

“I don't know.”

“What did he look like?”

“I never saw his face.”

She swallowed.

“But I heard him speaking to Obinna last night.”

Samson's stomach tightened.

“What did they talk about?”

Ngozi hesitated.

“The Hall of Memory.”

The room fell silent.

Chinedu's face went pale.

“Are you certain?”

“Yes.”

Samson clenched his fists.

Obinna knew about the Hall.

Someone had been watching the western wing.

Frimpong had brought a message from Ayine.

And somewhere beneath the palace was supposedly a bell that did not exist.

The pieces were finally beginning to form a picture.

But Samson still could not see the whole thing.

Then Ngozi whispered:

“There is one more thing.”

“What?”

“Before the stranger left, I heard him say something to Obinna.”

Samson waited.

Ngozi looked directly at him.

“He said, ‘If the boy reaches the Hall before we do, everything will be lost.’”

Samson's heart pounded.

He understood now.

They were no longer the only ones searching.

They were racing against someone.

And the race had already begun.

CHAPTER 7

The Nobleman's Secret

That night, Samson could not sleep.

The words of Frimpong kept returning to his mind.

“The bell beneath the palace.”

Then Ngozi's warning:

“If the boy reaches the Hall before we do, everything will be lost.”

Samson sat beside his window, staring at the palace courtyard.

A single lantern burned near the western wing.

Someone was still awake.

He wondered whether it was Obinna.

Or the stranger Ngozi had heard speaking with him.

Or perhaps someone else entirely.

Samson reached into his pocket and touched the bronze pendant.

He had learned one thing from the past few days:

Every answer seemed to lead to another question.

A quiet knock came at his door.

Samson stood immediately.

“Who is it?”

“It's Eze.”

Samson opened the door.

Eze entered quickly.

“You're still awake?”

“So are you.”

“I heard something.”

“What?”

Eze lowered his voice.

“Frimpong escaped.”

Samson's eyes widened.

“Escaped from the guardhouse?”

Eze nodded.

“How?”

“I don't know. But Ngozi helped him.”

Samson stared at him.

“Are you sure?”

“She told me herself.”

“Where are they?”

“Hidden somewhere near the old market.”

Samson grabbed his cloak.

“We're going.”

Eze stopped him.

“Wait.”

“What?”

“There is another problem.”

Samson looked at him.

“Obinna has summoned you tomorrow morning.”

“Why?”

“I don't know.”

Samson slowly sat down.

Then he understood.

“Because of Frimpong.”

“Probably.”

Samson looked toward the dark palace.

“Then tomorrow, I will let him ask his questions.”

Eze smiled.

“And what will you do?”

“Ask some of my own.”

The next morning, Samson entered Obinna's chamber.

Obinna was standing beside a large wooden table covered with maps and royal documents.

He did not invite Samson to sit.

“You have become very curious,” Obinna said.

Samson remained silent.

“First, you search the western wing.”

Samson's heart skipped.

Then Obinna continued.

“You question palace servants.”

“I asked questions.”

“You speak with strangers who arrive claiming that King Ayine is alive.”

“I did not know who he was when I met him.”

Obinna studied him.

“Do you believe Frimpong?”

Samson paused.

“I believe he knew King Ayine.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“Then I don't know.”

Obinna walked toward the table.

“Your curiosity is becoming dangerous.”

Samson remembered Atine's words.

He kept his voice calm.

“Why?”

“Because some people use the past to create chaos in the present.”

“Or perhaps they use silence to hide the truth.”

Obinna's expression hardened.

“Be careful.”

Samson looked directly at him.

“Were you involved in King Ayine's disappearance?”

The room became completely silent.

Obinna stared at him.

For a moment, Samson thought he might refuse to answer.

Instead, Obinna laughed softly.

“You are asking questions far beyond your position.”

“That isn't an answer.”

“No.”

Obinna stepped closer.

“It is a warning.”

Samson did not move.

“Did you know about the Hall of Memory?”

Obinna's face changed.

Only slightly.

But Samson saw it.

“Yes,” Obinna said.

“Then why did you pretend not to know?”

“I never said I didn't know.”

“What is inside it?”

Obinna looked away.

“History.”

“And the Crown Chronicle?”

Silence.

Samson knew he had struck something important.

Obinna finally spoke.

“Who told you that name?”

“No one.”

“Then you are lying.”

“I found it in the records.”

Obinna's eyes narrowed.

“You have no idea what you are dealing with.”

“Then tell me.”

Obinna leaned toward him.

“Leave the past alone.”

Samson stood.

“I can't.”

“Why?”

“Because the kingdom deserves to know what happened to its king.”

Obinna's voice became cold.

“Some kingdoms survive because their people know when to forget.”

Samson stared at him.

Then he turned and walked out.

Behind him, Obinna spoke one final sentence.

“If you continue, you may discover that the person you trust most is the person who betrayed you.”

Samson stopped.

But he did not turn around.

By sunset, Samson, Eze and Chinedu had found Ngozi.

She led them through a narrow path behind the old market.

Frimpong was waiting inside an abandoned storehouse.

He looked tired, but his eyes were alert.

“You came,” he said.

Samson nodded.

“We need answers.”

Frimpong smiled sadly.

“So did King Ayine.”

He sat down.

“I served him for many years.”

“You were his messenger?”

“Yes.”

“Where is he?”

Frimpong looked at Samson.

“I cannot tell you yet.”

“Why?”

“Because he made me promise.”

Samson became frustrated.

“You expect me to believe that?”

Frimpong reached into his bag.

He pulled out a small piece of parchment.

“This was written by the king.”

Samson opened it.

There were only a few words:

WHEN THE TIME COMES, TELL THEM ABOUT THE
TREASURY.

Samson looked up.

“The treasury?”

Frimpong nodded.

“King Ayine discovered that royal wealth was disappearing.”

“How much?”

“I don't know.”

“Who was taking it?”

“That is what he was trying to discover.”

Chinedu leaned forward.

“Was it someone inside the palace?”

Frimpong's silence answered the question.

Samson's voice became quieter.

“Obinna?”

Frimpong did not answer.

“Atiewin?”

Again, silence.

“Who?”

Frimpong looked at them.

“The king believed someone close to him was involved.”

“Did he know who?”

“He had suspicions.”

“What happened?”

Frimpong took a deep breath.

“He began checking the royal accounts himself. He discovered that records had been altered.”

Chinedu's eyes widened.

“Altered how?”

“Names disappeared. Amounts changed. Entire transactions were removed.”

“And the money?”

“Gone.”

Samson remembered the message from the old records.

THE DANGER IS NOT OUTSIDE THE PALACE.

“So Ayine knew someone inside the palace was stealing from the kingdom.”

“Yes.”

“And then he disappeared.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

Frimpong looked at him.

“Because he believed the people involved knew that he was getting close.”

Eze shook his head.

“So he ran away?”

“No.”

Frimpong's answer was firm.

“He did not run away.”

The boys looked at him.

“He disappeared deliberately.”

Samson's heart raced.

“Why would a king abandon his throne?”

“To find out who he could trust.”

Chinedu slowly understood.

“The Keepers.”

Frimpong looked at him.

“You know about them?”

“We found the records.”

Frimpong's face became serious.

“Then you must understand the danger.”

“What danger?”

“The Keepers were supposed to protect the truth.”

He paused.

“But someone turned them against one another.”

Samson remembered the words in the hidden document.

THE KEEPERS MUST NEVER TRUST ONE ANOTHER.

“Who?”

Frimpong shook his head.

“That is the question King Ayine never managed to answer.”

Suddenly, a noise came from outside.

Everyone froze.

Footsteps.

Someone was approaching.

Ngozi quickly moved toward the door.

“Someone is coming.”

Frimpong stood.

“Where is the back entrance?”

Ngozi pointed toward the rear wall.

“Go!”

The door opened.

A voice shouted, “Search the building!”

Frimpong disappeared through the back entrance.

Samson, Eze and Chinedu followed.

Ngozi stayed behind.

They ran through the narrow alley until the voices faded.

Finally, they stopped beneath an old tree.

Samson looked at Frimpong.

“Who were those men?”

“Obinna's guards.”

“How did they find us?”

Frimpong shook his head.

“I don't know.”

Samson looked back toward the storehouse.

Ngozi had stayed behind.

He hoped she would be safe.

Then Frimpong spoke.

“There is something else you must know.”

“What?”

“The treasury was not the only thing King Ayine discovered.”

Samson waited.

Frimpong looked around before continuing.

“He found evidence that someone had been preparing for his disappearance long before it happened.”

Samson felt a chill.

“Preparing?”

“Yes.”

“Meaning what?”

“Letters had been written.”

“To whom?”

“I don't know.”

“Then what do you know?”

Frimpong reached into his bag and removed a small folded cloth.

He opened it.

Inside was an old royal document.

Samson recognized the symbol immediately.

The eye.

The three curved lines.

But beneath it was something they had never seen before.

A name.

OBINNA.

Samson stared at it.

Eze stepped closer.

“That's impossible.”

Chinedu examined the writing.

“It is old.”

Samson looked at Frimpong.

“What does it mean?”

Frimpong's face was grim.

“I don't know.”

Then he added:

“But King Ayine told me one thing before he disappeared.”

“What?”

Frimpong looked directly at Samson.

“Never judge a man by the secret he appears to be hiding.”

Samson frowned.

“Why?”

“Because sometimes the secret is not his.”

A distant bell rang.

Once.

Samson looked toward the palace.

Frimpong's face suddenly went pale.

“The bell.”

Samson remembered.

The bell beneath the palace.

Frimpong whispered:

“It has begun.”

And somewhere beneath the ancient palace of Amachara, something answered with a second ring.

CHAPTER 8

Beneath the Palace

The second bell rang beneath the palace.

This time, there was no mistaking it.

Dong.

The sound travelled through the ground beneath their feet.

Samson looked at Frimpong.

“What is happening?”

Frimpong's face was tense.

“The Hall of Memory has been opened.”

Chinedu shook his head.

“That cannot be possible.”

“Why?”

“Because we don't know where the entrance is.”

Frimpong looked at Samson.

“Perhaps you do.”

Samson remembered the hidden passage in the western wing.

The symbol.

The royal seal.

The message.

And the words:

THE CROWN IS NOT WHERE THEY THINK IT IS.

He suddenly understood.

“We have to return to the palace.”

Eze stared at him.

“Now?”

“Now.”

They waited until darkness covered Amachara.

The palace guards were changing shifts, and the main courtyard was unusually quiet.

Samson, Eze and Chinedu entered through a small side passage they had used before.

Frimpong remained behind.

“You should not come with us,” Samson told him.

Frimpong nodded.

“I will wait here.”

“If we don't return—”

“Do not say that.”

Samson smiled faintly.

“Then we'll return.”

They slipped into the western wing.

The abandoned corridor looked different at night.

The walls seemed taller.

The shadows deeper.

Every sound echoed.

Chinedu carried the old record they had discovered.

“We need to find the entrance.”

Samson looked at the wall.

“The hidden passage must be connected to the symbol.”

They searched carefully.

Eze noticed something.

“Samson.”

He pointed toward the floor.

Three curved lines had been carved into the stone.

Above them was an eye.

Samson knelt.

“The symbol.”

Chinedu examined it.

“There must be a mechanism.”

Samson remembered the royal seal.

He removed it from his pocket and pressed it against the carved symbol.

For several seconds, nothing happened.

Then—

Click.

A section of the floor moved.

Eze stepped back.

The stone slowly slid aside, revealing a narrow staircase descending into darkness.

Nobody spoke.

Finally, Eze whispered:

“Well, that explains the bell.”

Samson looked into the darkness.

“Let's go.”

The staircase seemed to continue forever.

The air became cooler as they descended.

The walls were covered with faded carvings—kings, farmers, warriors, children, ceremonies and ancient symbols.

Chinedu stopped several times to study them.

“These are older than the palace.”

“How is that possible?” Eze asked.

“The palace may have been built over something much older.”

Samson touched one of the carvings.

“Look.”

A sentence had been carved beneath it.

A KING MAY HOLD THE CROWN, BUT THE PEOPLE HOLD THE MEMORY.

Samson smiled.

“That sounds like something Ayine would say.”

They continued downward.

At the bottom, the staircase opened into a vast underground chamber.

Torches suddenly came alive along the walls.

Eze jumped.

“Who lit those?”

No one answered.

In front of them stood a huge bronze door.

The eye symbol was carved into its center.

Below it were the words:

ONLY THOSE WHO REMEMBER MAY ENTER.

Chinedu stared at the inscription.

“How do we open it?”

Samson looked around.

Then he noticed three objects carved into the wall beside the door.

A crown.

A book.

A bell.

“The clues,” he said.

Eze pointed at the crown.

“The crown is first.”

“No,” Samson said.

He remembered the message.

The crown is not where they think it is.

He pointed at the book.

“Memory.”

Then the bell.

“The bell.”

He touched them in that order.

Book. Bell. Crown.

Nothing happened.

Eze sighed.

“Maybe we were wrong.”

Samson thought.

Then he remembered Atine's words.

When the root is rotten, the fruit cannot remain healthy.

The answer was not the crown.

It was the memory beneath it.

He pressed the book again.

Then the bell.

Finally, the crown.

The bronze door opened.

The Hall of Memory was enormous.

Shelves covered every wall.

They were filled with scrolls, books, boxes and sealed containers.

At the center stood a large stone table.

Upon it lay a single book.

Its cover was black.

A golden crown had been carved into it.

Chinedu slowly approached.

“The Crown Chronicle.”

Samson's heart raced.

They had found it.

Chinedu opened the book.

The first pages contained records of King Ayine's reign.

Important decisions.

Royal agreements.

Treasury reports.

Names of officials.

Then the entries became darker.

Chinedu turned the pages carefully.

“There.”

A record showed missing money from the royal treasury.

Another showed payments made without the king's approval.

Then another.

And another.

Samson's face tightened.

“Someone was stealing from the kingdom.”

Chinedu nodded.

“But look at this.”

He pointed to a page.

Several names had been written beside the missing funds.

Then crossed out.

One name appeared repeatedly.

OBINNA.

Eze stared.

“So it really was him.”

“Not so fast,” Chinedu said.

“What?”

“Look at the next page.”

They turned it.

There was a note written in King Ayine's handwriting.

OBINNA IS BEING WATCHED.

Samson frowned.

“Watched by whom?”

They turned another page.

Another note.

HE MAY NOT BE THE MASTER.

Silence.

Eze looked confused.

“Then who is?”

The next page had been torn out.

Chinedu turned several more pages.

More pages were missing.

Someone had deliberately removed them.

Samson looked around the chamber.

“How many people knew about this place?”

Chinedu shook his head.

“I don't know.”

Then Samson noticed something beneath the table.

A small wooden box.

He pulled it out.

Inside was a folded document.

The royal seal was still intact.

He opened it.

The first sentence made his heart stop.

IF YOU ARE READING THIS, THEN THE THRONE HAS
REMAINED EMPTY.

Samson continued.

I did not disappear because I abandoned my kingdom. I disappeared
because I could no longer trust the palace around me.

Eze stared at the page.

“He knew.”

Samson read on.

The theft from the treasury is only one part of the truth. The greater
danger is the person who wants the throne badly enough to destroy
anyone standing between him and it.

Samson slowly looked at Eze.

“Obinna.”

But Chinedu shook his head.

“Read the next line.”

Samson did.

Do not accuse the man who appears guilty until you discover who
benefits from his guilt.

Samson stopped.

The room suddenly felt colder.

Someone had carefully arranged the evidence around Obinna.

But why?

Who was really behind it?

Then Samson saw another sentence.

I will return when the evidence is complete. Until then, the throne must remain empty.

Eze whispered:

“He planned to come back.”

Samson nodded.

“He's alive.”

A sound came from behind them.

Footsteps.

The three boys turned.

Someone was walking through the Hall of Memory.

Slowly.

Calmly.

Getting closer.

Chinedu quickly closed the Chronicle.

Eze whispered, “We have to hide.”

They moved behind a row of shelves.

The footsteps stopped.

A shadow appeared across the floor.

Someone had entered the chamber.

Samson held his breath.

The stranger walked toward the stone table.

Then stopped.

A hand reached out.

It picked up the Crown Chronicle.

Samson could not see the person's face.

But he recognized the voice.

“You should never have opened this door.”

Samson's eyes widened.

He knew that voice.

It belonged to someone he trusted.

Someone who had been helping them from the beginning.

Someone who knew far more about King Ayine than they had ever admitted.

The person stepped into the light.

Samson's heart dropped.

Atiewin.

The elderly royal adviser looked at the three boys.

He held the Crown Chronicle in his hands.

And behind him, another figure quietly locked the bronze door.

CHAPTER 9

The Truth About the King

For several seconds, nobody moved.

Samson stared at Atiewin.

The elderly adviser stood beneath the torchlight, holding the Crown Chronicle against his chest.

Behind him stood the second figure.

The bronze door was locked.

“You,” Samson whispered.

Atiewin's eyes were filled with sadness.

“Yes.”

Eze stepped forward.

“You followed us?”

“No.”

“Then how did you know we were here?”

Atiewin looked at the Crown Chronicle.

“Because I have been waiting for this night.”

Samson frowned.

“Waiting?”

“For someone to finally open the Hall.”

Chinedu looked at him.

“You knew about it.”

“I did.”

“And you knew about the Keepers.”

“Yes.”

Samson's voice became sharper.

“Then why didn't you tell us?”

Atiewin lowered his head.

“Because some truths must be protected until the right person is ready to carry them.”

“You kept the truth from us!”

“I protected it.”

“From whom?”

Atiewin looked toward the locked door.

“From those who wanted it destroyed.”

The second figure stepped forward.

Samson recognized him.

Achampong, captain of the palace guards.

Eze's eyes widened.

“You too?”

Achampong nodded.

“I have been protecting this secret for years.”

Samson looked from one man to the other.

“Then tell us everything.”

Atiewin placed the Crown Chronicle on the stone table.

“King Ayine did not die.”

Silence.

Samson already suspected it.

But hearing the words aloud was different.

“You knew he was alive?”

Atiewin nodded.

“I did.”

“Where is he?”

“I cannot tell you.”

Samson clenched his fists.

“Everyone keeps saying that!”

Atiewin raised a hand.

“Listen before you judge.”

He opened the Crown Chronicle.

“On the night Ayine disappeared, he discovered that someone had been stealing from the royal treasury.”

“We know,” Chinedu said.

“You know only part of it.”

Atiewin turned a page.

“The theft was being carried out through false records. Money was being moved through several royal accounts and then transferred elsewhere.”

“Who was doing it?” Eze asked.

Atiewin looked at him.

“That was the question Ayine could not answer.”

Samson remembered the note.

OBINNA MAY NOT BE THE MASTER.

“So Obinna was involved?”

“At first, we believed he was.”

“What changed?”

Atiewin pointed to another page.

“King Ayine discovered that Obinna's name was being used to approve transactions he had never authorized.”

Chinedu's eyes widened.

“Someone was framing him.”

“Yes.”

Samson stared at the page.

“So the evidence against Obinna was planted.”

“Some of it.”

“Who did it?”

Atiewin shook his head.

“We never found out.”

Samson looked at Achampong.

“And you helped the king disappear?”

Achampong nodded.

“I was ordered to protect him.”

“Why didn't you tell anyone?”

“Because the person Ayine feared was inside the palace.”

Samson remembered the message.

THE DANGER IS NOT OUTSIDE THE PALACE.

Atiewin continued.

“Ayine believed that if he remained in the palace, the people responsible would eventually silence him.”

“So he left.”

“He disappeared.”

“Where did he go?”

Atiewin looked toward the dark ceiling.

“He went somewhere even the palace could not reach.”

Samson stepped closer.

“Is he still alive?”

Atiewin looked directly into his eyes.

“Yes.”

Samson felt a wave of relief.

After all these years, the empty throne was not the memorial of a dead king.

It was the place where a living king had been waiting.

“But why hasn't he returned?”

Atiewin's face became serious.

“Because the danger was never completely removed.”

“What danger?”

“The person behind the conspiracy.”

Samson thought of Obinna.

“Who?”

“We don't know.”

“Then how can you expect us to find him?”

Atiewin looked at Samson.

“Because Ayine left one final clue.”

He reached inside his robe and removed a small piece of parchment.

Samson recognized the symbol immediately.

Atiewin placed it on the table.

“Your king wrote this before he disappeared.”

Samson unfolded it.

There were only a few lines.

WHEN THE BELL RINGS THREE TIMES, FOLLOW THE ROAD
OF THE FORGOTTEN.

Samson looked up.

“The bell.”

Atiewin nodded.

“The bell beneath the palace.”

“How do we find it?”

Achampong stepped toward the wall.

“There is another chamber.”

He pressed a stone.

A section of the wall opened.

Beyond it was a narrow passage.

Samson stared.

“How many secret passages does this palace have?”

Achampong smiled faintly.

“More than you would believe.”

They entered.

The passage was narrow and old.

Their footsteps echoed as they walked.

After several minutes, they reached a small chamber.

At its center stood a bronze bell.

Samson stared.

“So it was real.”

Atiewin nodded.

“This bell was used by the Keepers.”

Chinedu examined the inscriptions around it.

“The symbol again.”

Below the symbol was a sentence:

WHEN MEMORY CALLS, THE ROAD OPENS.

Atiewin handed Samson a small wooden mallet.

“Strike it.”

Samson hesitated.

“What will happen?”

“That is what we are about to discover.”

Samson struck the bell.

DONG.

The sound shook the chamber.

For a moment, nothing happened.

Then the ground trembled.

A hidden doorway opened behind the bell.

Cold air rushed into the chamber.

Beyond the doorway was a long underground tunnel.

Atiewin looked at Samson.

“The road of the forgotten.”

They followed the tunnel for what seemed like hours.

Eventually, daylight appeared ahead.

They emerged beyond the kingdom's outer boundary.

A narrow road stretched between tall trees.

Atiewin pointed toward the distance.

“Follow that road.”

“Where does it lead?”

“To an old settlement.”

“Who lives there?”

Atiewin did not answer.

Samson looked at Achampong.

The captain simply said:

“You will know when you arrive.”

They continued alone.

Atiewin and Achampong remained behind.

“Why aren't you coming?” Eze asked.

“Because our part is finished,” Atiewin replied.

Samson looked at him.

“Thank you.”

Atiewin smiled.

“Do not thank me yet.”

The road became narrower.

Eventually, they reached a small settlement hidden among the trees.

It looked almost abandoned.

A few houses stood around a central fire.

An elderly man sat beside it.

His back was turned toward them.

Samson stopped.

Something about the man seemed familiar.

The stranger slowly turned.

Samson froze.

He knew that face.

He had seen it many times.

In paintings.

On the royal seal.

In the old portraits hanging inside the palace.

The man stood.

His hair had become gray.

His face was older.

But his eyes were unmistakable.

Samson whispered:

“King Ayine.”

The old man smiled.

“Yes.”

Eze stared.

Chinedu could barely speak.

For years, Amachara had believed its king was gone.

But he was standing before them.

Alive.

Samson stepped forward.

“Why did you leave us?”

Ayine looked toward the distant kingdom.

“Because I believed that returning too soon would place everyone in greater danger.”

“Did you know people thought you were dead?”

“Yes.”

“Why did you allow it?”

Ayine's expression became heavy.

“Sometimes a king must disappear so that the truth can survive.”

Samson remembered the empty throne.

“All these years...”

“I know.”

“Did you ever plan to return?”

Ayine nodded.

“The moment I discovered who was responsible.”

Samson's heart raced.

“You know who did it?”

Ayine looked at him.

“I know who helped.”

“And the person behind everything?”

Ayine's expression darkened.

“I believe I know.”

“Who?”

Before Ayine could answer, a sound came from the trees.

A branch snapped.

Everyone turned.

Someone was watching them.

Ayine immediately stood.

“Get inside.”

“Why?”

“Now!”

The boys hurried toward the house.

Ayine looked toward the forest.

His face had changed.

The calm king was gone.

In his place stood a man who had spent years expecting danger.

Then a voice came from the darkness.

“Your Majesty.”

Ayine froze.

Samson looked at him.

The voice continued.

“You should have stayed forgotten.”

Ayine's eyes narrowed.

“After all these years...”

He stepped forward.

“...you finally found me.”

And from somewhere among the trees came the sound of a third bell.

CHAPTER 10

Betrayal

The third bell faded into the night.

No one spoke.

King Ayine stood at the entrance of the small house, staring into the forest.

Samson could hear his own heartbeat.

“Who is there?” Ayine called.

The trees remained still.

Then a figure stepped into the moonlight.

Samson recognized him immediately.

Obinna.

Eze whispered, “It can't be.”

Chinedu stared in disbelief.

Obinna walked slowly toward the house.

Behind him were several armed guards.

Samson looked at King Ayine.

“You knew.”

Ayine nodded.

“I suspected.”

Obinna stopped several steps away.

For a moment, the two men simply stared at each other.

The missing king and the man who had spent years standing near his empty throne.

Finally, Obinna spoke.

“You should have remained hidden.”

Ayine's voice was calm.

“You should have remained patient.”

Obinna laughed.

“Patient?”

He looked toward Samson.

“I waited years.”

“For what?”

“The crown.”

Samson's expression hardened.

“So it was you.”

Obinna shook his head.

“No.”

Everyone looked at him.

“I wanted the throne,” he admitted. “But I did not make the king disappear.”

Ayine stepped forward.

“Then tell them the truth.”

Obinna's face tightened.

"You don't understand what happened."

"Then explain it."

Obinna looked at Samson.

"Your king discovered the treasury theft."

"We know."

"He discovered that several nobles were involved."

"Who?"

Obinna hesitated.

"People more powerful than I was."

Samson frowned.

"Then why were your names in the records?"

"Because they used me."

"How?"

"They forged my seal. They used my name to authorize payments."

Chinedu stepped forward.

"That is why some of the records were altered."

Obinna nodded.

"I realized what was happening too late."

Samson stared at him.

"But you wanted the throne."

"Yes."

“Then why should we believe you?”

Obinna looked toward Ayine.

“Because I made the greatest mistake of my life.”

“What mistake?”

“I thought that if Ayine disappeared, the throne would eventually be mine.”

Silence.

“I was wrong.”

Ayine's expression remained serious.

“You were.”

Obinna lowered his head.

“I wanted power. I allowed my ambition to blind me.”

Samson remembered Atine's warning.

When the root is rotten, the fruit cannot remain healthy.

But there was still something missing.

“Who was behind the theft?” Samson asked.

Obinna looked toward the forest.

Before he could answer, one of the guards behind him stepped forward.

“Enough.”

Obinna turned.

The guard removed his helmet.

Samson's eyes widened.

It was not one of Obinna's ordinary soldiers.

It was a senior royal official who had served in the palace for years.

Nwosu.

Samson had seen him countless times beside the royal council.

Nwosu smiled.

“You have all made this unnecessarily difficult.”

Ayine's expression changed.

“You.”

Nwosu nodded.

“At last.”

Obinna turned toward him.

“You told me the king was dead.”

“I told you what you needed to believe.”

“You used me.”

“Of course.”

Obinna's face filled with anger.

“You framed me.”

“Yes.”

“You stole from the treasury using my seal.”

“Yes.”

Obinna stepped forward.

“Why?”

Nwosu laughed.

“Because you were ambitious.”

He pointed toward Obinna.

“Everyone already believed you wanted the throne. You were the perfect person to blame.”

Samson finally understood.

The evidence against Obinna had not been completely false.

It had been carefully designed.

Nwosu had used Obinna's ambition to hide his own crime.

Ayine spoke.

“You wanted control of the kingdom.”

Nwosu nodded.

“The treasury gave me wealth. The empty throne gave me influence.”

“And the king?”

“I needed him gone.”

“You failed.”

Nwosu's smile disappeared.

“Yes.”

He looked at Samson.

“But I am not the only one who knows the truth.”

Samson felt a chill.

“What do you mean?”

Nwosu pointed toward the forest.

“Search the palace.”

Ayine's eyes narrowed.

“What have you done?”

Nwosu smiled.

“Nothing that cannot be undone.”

Then he gave a signal.

The guards moved forward.

Everything happened quickly.

Ayine pushed Samson toward the house.

“Stay inside!”

“But—”

“Go!”

Obinna suddenly stepped in front of Nwosu.

“You will not touch him.”

Nwosu stared at him.

“You still think you can become a hero?”

“No.”

Obinna looked at Samson.

“I am simply finished being your tool.”

The guards hesitated.

Then a whistle sounded from the forest.

More footsteps approached.

But this time, they were not Nwosu's men.

Achampong emerged from the trees with a group of loyal palace guards.

Atiewin walked beside him.

Nwosu's face went pale.

“You.”

Atiewin looked at him calmly.

“We have been waiting for you to reveal yourself.”

Nwosu looked around.

“How?”

Atiewin smiled.

“Because you made one mistake.”

“What mistake?”

“You believed everyone was afraid of the truth.”

He pointed toward Samson.

“You forgot that some people are willing to protect it.”

Nwosu looked at Ayine.

Then Obinna.

Then the guards surrounding him.

He realized he had lost.

He dropped his weapon.

The guards seized him.

Later that night, everyone gathered inside the old settlement.

Ayine sat beside the fire.

Samson sat opposite him.

For the first time, he could ask the question he had carried for years.

“Why didn't you come home earlier?”

Ayine looked into the flames.

“Because I needed proof.”

“But you had the evidence.”

“Not enough.”

He pointed toward the Crown Chronicle.

“The people of Amachara deserved more than rumors. They deserved the truth.”

Chinedu nodded.

“And the Keepers?”

Ayine looked at Atiewin.

“They protected the records.”

Atiewin lowered his head.

“Some of us failed.”

Ayine shook his head.

“Some made mistakes. But others kept the truth alive.”

Samson looked at Obinna.

“What will happen to him?”

Obinna stood quietly nearby.

Ayine answered:

“That will be decided according to the laws of Amachara.”

Obinna nodded.

“I accept that.”

Samson looked at him.

“You wanted the throne.”

Obinna gave a sad smile.

“Yes.”

“Do you still want it?”

Obinna looked toward Ayine.

Then toward the road leading home.

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because I finally understand something.”

“What?”

“A throne is not a prize.”

He paused.

“It is a responsibility.”

Samson smiled faintly.

Perhaps Obinna had learned the lesson too late.

But perhaps not too late to change.

Before dawn, Ayine stood outside the house.

Samson joined him.

“Are you ready to return?”

Ayine looked toward Amachara.

“I have been ready for years.”

“Then why do you look worried?”

Ayine smiled.

“Because returning is easier than ruling.”

Samson frowned.

“What do you mean?”

“A king can uncover a crime. A king can defeat an enemy. But rebuilding trust takes much longer.”

He placed a hand on Samson's shoulder.

“Remember that.”

Samson nodded.

As the first light appeared beyond the trees, the people of the settlement prepared to leave.

The empty throne was no longer empty because its owner had been found.

But Samson knew their journey was not over.

They had uncovered the betrayal.

They had found the king.

Now they had to return to Amachara and face the people.

And there was one final question:

Would the kingdom believe the truth?

CHAPTER 11

The Return

The journey back to Amachara began before sunrise.

King Ayine walked at the front.

Behind him came Samson, Eze, Chinedu, Atiewin, Achampong, Obinna, and the guards who had remained loyal to the kingdom.

For most of the journey, nobody spoke.

There was too much to think about.

For years, Amachara had believed its king was dead.

For years, the throne had remained empty.

Now the king was coming home.

But Samson wondered what would happen when the people saw him.

Would they celebrate?

Would they doubt him?

Would they be angry?

Perhaps all three.

As they approached the outer fields of the kingdom, they saw farmers working in the distance.

One farmer noticed the group first.

He stopped.

Then another.

Soon, people began gathering along the road.

Whispers spread through the crowd.

“Who is that?”

“Is that...?”

“No. It cannot be.”

Then an elderly woman dropped the basket she was carrying.

“King Ayine!”

The words travelled through the crowd like fire through dry grass.

Within minutes, people were running toward the road.

Some laughed.

Some cried.

Others simply stood in disbelief.

Ayine raised his hand.

“My people.”

The crowd became silent.

He looked at the faces before him.

“I know you have questions.”

A voice from the crowd called out:

“Where have you been?”

Ayine lowered his head.

“I should have returned sooner.”

Another voice shouted:

“Why did you leave us?”

Ayine answered honestly.

“Because I believed someone inside the kingdom wanted the truth destroyed.”

The crowd began murmuring.

Ayine continued.

“I did not leave because I stopped loving Amachara. I left because I believed that remaining would put the kingdom in greater danger.”

Samson watched the people carefully.

Some were beginning to understand.

Others remained uncertain.

Then Chinedu stepped forward.

He held up the Crown Chronicle.

“The records prove what happened.”

The crowd grew quiet.

Chinedu explained the missing treasury funds, the forged records, and the attempt to make Obinna appear responsible.

Then Achampong spoke.

“I served King Ayine secretly after his disappearance. I witnessed the evidence he collected.”

Atiewin stepped forward.

“And I knew the king was alive.”

A murmur moved through the crowd.

“You knew?”

“Yes.”

Atiewin bowed his head.

“I kept the secret because I believed revealing it too early would put his life in danger.”

Then Obinna stepped forward.

Everyone became silent.

He looked at the people of Amachara.

“I wanted the throne.”

A gasp moved through the crowd.

“I allowed ambition to blind me. I believed the king was gone, and I thought the empty throne was an opportunity.”

He looked toward Ayine.

“But I did not cause his disappearance.”

Ayine nodded.

“The truth must include both his mistakes and the crimes committed against him.”

Obinna lowered his head.

“I accept whatever judgment the kingdom gives me.”

By midday, the palace courtyard was filled with people.

The empty throne stood beneath the great canopy.

It looked exactly as it had for years.

But this time, everyone was staring at it for a different reason.

Ayine walked toward the throne.

He stopped before it.

Samson stood behind him.

For a moment, the king did not sit.

Instead, he turned toward the people.

“I once believed that protecting the kingdom meant protecting the throne.”

He looked at the empty seat.

“I was wrong.”

The crowd listened.

“A throne is only wood and stone. A kingdom is its people.”

He placed his hand on the arm of the throne.

“And a king who forgets that is no better than a man who has lost his way.”

Then he sat.

The crowd erupted.

Drums sounded across the courtyard.

People cheered.

The years of uncertainty seemed to break apart in a single moment.

But Samson noticed something.

Ayine did not smile immediately.

He looked toward the palace entrance.

As if he knew that restoring the throne was only the beginning.

That evening, Samson found Atine beneath her old tree.

She was smiling.

“You were right,” Samson said.

“About what?”

“The truth found its way home.”

Atine chuckled.

“I told you it never forgets.”

Samson sat beside her.

“Grandmother, there is something I still don't understand.”

“What?”

“Why did Ayine choose me?”

Atine looked at him.

“Perhaps he saw something in you.”

“What?”

“The courage to ask questions.”

Samson smiled.

“I was afraid.”

“Courage does not mean having no fear.”

She picked up a small stone from the ground.

“It means refusing to let fear make your decisions.”

Samson looked toward the palace.

“The kingdom is different now.”

“Yes.”

“Do you think everything will be peaceful?”

Atine laughed softly.

“My child, even the calmest river has stones beneath its surface.”

Samson smiled.

“Then there may still be trouble.”

“There will always be trouble.”

She placed the stone back on the ground.

“But a wise person learns from yesterday before walking into tomorrow.”

Samson looked at her.

“Is that another proverb?”

Atine smiled.

“Perhaps.”

That night, the palace bells rang across Amachara.

One.

Two.

Three.

Then the great bronze bell beneath the palace rang once more.

But this time, nobody was afraid.

The sound travelled through the kingdom.

For years, it had been a warning.

Now it sounded like a promise.

The promise that the past would no longer be hidden.

The promise that the truth would be preserved.

And the promise that the people of Amachara would remember.

Samson stood beneath the palace courtyard and looked toward the throne.

He thought about everything that had happened.

The hidden symbol.

The forgotten records.

The secret passage.

The Hall of Memory.

The betrayal.

The missing king.

And the people who had risked everything to protect the truth.

He finally understood what the symbol truly meant.

It was not merely a mark.

It was a reminder.

Remember.

Because a kingdom that remembers its past can choose a better future.

Far beyond the palace, beneath an old tree, a small group of villagers gathered around a fire.

One of them was telling the story of King Ayine.

A child interrupted.

“Did the king really disappear?”

“Yes.”

“And did Samson find him?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

The storyteller smiled.

“He followed the clues.”

“What clues?”

The old storyteller pointed toward the stars.

“Sometimes, when the truth is hidden, you must learn how to read the signs.”

The child thought for a moment.

“Will people remember this story?”

The storyteller smiled.

“That depends on you.”

The child frowned.

“Me?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because every generation becomes a Keeper of Memory.”

The child looked toward the distant palace.

And somewhere beneath it, the ancient bronze bell rested in silence.

Waiting.

Not for danger.

But for the next generation to remember.

CHAPTER 12

The Throne

The morning after King Ayine's return, Amachara awoke to a kingdom transformed.

The drums began before sunrise.

Women decorated the streets with fresh leaves and bright cloth. Farmers came from distant villages. Children gathered near the palace gates, eager to see the king whose disappearance had become one of the greatest mysteries in the kingdom's history.

But inside the palace, King Ayine was not celebrating.

He was working.

The royal council had gathered.

Documents covered the long wooden table.

Treasury records.

Old agreements.

Witness statements.

Names.

Dates.

Evidence.

Everything that had been hidden for years was finally being examined.

Samson stood quietly at the side of the room.

He watched his king carefully.

Ayine looked older than the paintings suggested.

But there was strength in his eyes.

“Your Majesty,” one council member said, “what should happen to the people who helped Nwosu?”

Ayine looked around the room.

“Each person must answer for his own actions.”

“And Obinna?”

Ayine turned toward him.

Obinna stood at the far end of the chamber.

He no longer looked like the ambitious nobleman who had dreamed of the throne.

“I will accept the judgment of the council,” Obinna said.

Ayine nodded.

“Then let justice decide.”

Samson understood something important.

The king had returned, but he had not returned seeking revenge.

He wanted justice.

There was a difference.

Several days later, the people gathered in the great courtyard.

King Ayine stood before them.

Beside him stood Samson.

Atiewin.

Achampong.

Chinedu.

Eze.

Ngozi.

Each had played a part in bringing the truth into the light.

Ayine raised his hand.

“My people, Amachara has lived with an empty throne for many years.”

Everyone became silent.

“During that time, many stories were told.”

Some people nodded.

“Some believed I was dead. Others believed I had abandoned you. Some even believed the throne itself had become cursed.”

A few people laughed softly.

Ayine smiled.

“But there was one thing we all forgot.”

He looked toward the palace.

“A kingdom is not defined by the throne.”

He turned toward the people.

“It is defined by those who stand beneath it.”

The crowd applauded.

Ayine continued.

“We have uncovered betrayal. We have uncovered theft. We have uncovered lies.”

He paused.

“But we have also uncovered courage.”

He looked at Samson.

“Courage from those who refused to forget.”

Samson lowered his head.

Ayine then turned toward Chinedu.

“From those who searched the old records.”

Chinedu smiled.

Then toward Achampong.

“From those who protected the truth when doing so was dangerous.”

Achampong bowed.

Then toward Ngozi.

“From those whose voices were small but whose courage was great.”

Ngozi smiled.

Finally, Ayine looked toward Atiewin.

“And from those who carried a burden for many years because they believed the right time would come.”

Atiewin bowed his head.

The crowd applauded again.

That evening, Samson returned to the Hall of Memory.

The room was quiet.

He walked among the shelves, looking at the thousands of records preserved there.

He finally understood why the Hall had been protected so carefully.

These were not merely books.

They were the memory of Amachara.

The victories.

The mistakes.

The sacrifices.

The failures.

The lessons.

Samson stopped before the Crown Chronicle.

He opened it.

The final pages were still blank.

Chinedu entered behind him.

“You're here.”

Samson smiled.

“I wanted to see it again.”

Chinedu looked at the empty pages.

“There is something missing.”

“What?”

“The ending.”

Samson looked at him.

“You mean the record of what happened?”

“Yes.”

Samson picked up a pen.

“What should we write?”

Chinedu smiled.

“The truth.”

Together, they began.

They wrote about King Ayine's disappearance.

They wrote about the treasury.

They wrote about the false records.

They wrote about Nwosu's betrayal.

They wrote about Obinna's ambition.

They wrote about the people who protected the king.

They wrote about the empty throne.

And they wrote about the young people who refused to stop asking questions.

When they finished, Samson placed the pen down.

The Crown Chronicle was no longer incomplete.

Years later, children would gather beneath the old tree near Atine's home.

They would ask the storytellers to tell them about the king who disappeared.

The storyteller would begin:

“Once, there was a kingdom with a throne that nobody sat upon...”

The children would listen.

They would hear about the mysterious symbol.

The hidden chamber.

The bronze bell.

The forgotten records.

The betrayal.

And the return of the king.

But the storyteller would always end with the same lesson.

“The greatest treasure of a kingdom is not gold.”

The children would ask:

“Then what is it?”

The storyteller would smile.

“Memory.”

Because gold can be stolen.

Buildings can fall.

Kings can disappear.

But when people remember the truth, the heart of a kingdom continues to beat.

Many years later, Samson would stand before the same throne.

He would remember the boy he had once been.

The boy who stared at an empty seat and wondered why nobody sat there.

The boy who followed a strange symbol.

The boy who was warned to stop.

The boy who was afraid but continued.

He would remember Atine's words.

“Courage does not mean having no fear.”

He would remember King Ayine's words.

“A kingdom is its people.”

And he would remember the lesson written in the Hall of Memory:

A king may hold the crown, but the people hold the memory.

Samson looked at the throne one final time.

He understood now.

The empty throne had never been merely a mystery.

It had been a lesson.

A lesson about power.

About trust.

About ambition.

About betrayal.

And most importantly, about truth.

A crown could be placed upon a head.

A throne could be built from the finest wood.

A kingdom could possess great wealth.

But none of these things could make a true leader.

A true leader had to serve.

Had to listen.

Had to remember.

And had to place the people above himself.

The sun began to set over Amachara.

The palace bells rang across the kingdom.

Samson smiled.

The throne was no longer empty.

But the story would never truly end.

Because every generation would have its own throne.

Its own choices.

Its own secrets.

And its own responsibility to remember.

A crown may rest upon a head, but leadership must rest upon the heart.

And so the people of Amachara remembered.

And because they remembered, the kingdom lived. THE EMPTY
THRONE

LIFE LESSONS

1. Truth may be hidden, but it should never be forgotten.

The truth about King Ayine remained hidden for years, but eventually it came to light. We should value honesty and seek the truth, even when it is difficult.

2. Courage does not mean having no fear.

Samson was afraid many times, but he refused to allow fear to stop him from doing what he believed was right.

3. Ambition must be guided by wisdom.

Obinna wanted the throne so badly that his ambition nearly destroyed his judgment. Wanting success is not wrong, but ambition without wisdom can lead us into serious mistakes.

4. Trust should be earned.

Samson learned that people should not be trusted simply because they are powerful, respected, or close to the throne. Trust grows through actions and character.

5. Power is a responsibility.

King Ayine learned that being a king was not simply about sitting on a throne. Leadership means serving and protecting the people.

6. History teaches us how to build the future.

The Hall of Memory showed that a kingdom's past contains lessons for future generations. Remembering history helps people avoid repeating old mistakes.

7. Small acts of courage can make a great difference.

Ngozi, Chinedu, Eze, Achampong, and others each played a part in uncovering the truth. No contribution was too small.

8. Do not judge too quickly.

Obinna appeared guilty because evidence pointed toward him. But the truth was more complicated. We should seek understanding before making judgments.

9. Mistakes do not have to define a person forever.

Obinna made serious mistakes, but eventually admitted them. Accepting responsibility is an important step toward becoming better.

10. A good leader serves others.

The greatest lesson of the empty throne was simple: leadership is not about possessing power. It is about using responsibility wisely for the good of others.

QUESTIONS ABOUT THE STORY

Comprehension Questions

1. Why was the throne of Amachara left empty for so many years?
2. What happened to King Ayine?
3. What mysterious symbol did Samson discover?
4. What did the symbol represent?
5. Who helped Samson investigate the mystery?
6. What was the Hall of Memory?
7. What was the Crown Chronicle?
8. Why did King Ayine disappear?
9. What problem had King Ayine discovered in the royal treasury?
10. Why was Obinna initially suspected?
11. Who had been using Obinna's name and seal?
12. What role did Atiewin play in protecting the truth?
13. How did Achampong help King Ayine?
14. What message did Frimpong bring?
15. What did Samson learn about true leadership?

Thinking Questions

16. Do you think King Ayine was right to disappear? Explain your answer.
17. Was Obinna completely innocent? Why or why not?

18. Why do you think Nwosu chose Obinna to take the blame?
19. What could have happened if Samson had obeyed the warning to stop asking questions?
20. Which character showed the greatest courage? Give reasons for your choice.
21. What does the empty throne symbolize in the story?
22. Why was the Hall of Memory important to Amachara?
23. What can young people learn from Samson?
24. How can history help a community avoid repeating its mistakes?
25. What do you think is the most important lesson in the story?

PROVERBS & IDIOMS

1. “When the root is rotten, the fruit cannot remain healthy.”

Meaning: Problems at the foundation of something will eventually affect everything built upon it.

2. “A kingdom is its people.”

Meaning: A nation or community is more than its buildings, leaders, or possessions. Its people are its greatest strength.

3. “Truth may hide for many years, but it never forgets the way home.”

Meaning: Lies may hide the truth temporarily, but the truth can eventually be discovered.

4. “A crown may rest upon a head, but leadership must rest upon the heart.”

Meaning: Having authority does not automatically make someone a good leader. True leadership requires compassion, responsibility, and service.

5. “The past is a teacher.”

Meaning: We can learn valuable lessons by studying what happened before us.

6. “Do not judge a book by its cover.”

Meaning: Do not judge a person or situation only by what appears on the surface.

7. “Actions speak louder than words.”

Meaning: What people do often tells us more about their character than what they say.

8. “All that glitters is not gold.”

Meaning: Something that looks valuable or attractive may not actually be good or worthwhile.

9. “A wise person learns from the past.”

Meaning: Wisdom comes from understanding previous experiences and using them to make better decisions.

10. “United we stand, divided we fall.”

Meaning: People are stronger when they work together rather than allowing disagreements to separate them.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

The Empty Throne is a story about mystery, courage, leadership, trust, and the importance of remembering the past.

Through Samson's journey, we see that discovering the truth is not always easy. Sometimes the truth is hidden behind fear, ambition, silence, and betrayal. Yet even when the truth seems buried, there are always people willing to search for it.

The story also reminds us that leadership is not about possessing a crown or sitting upon a throne. True leadership is about responsibility, service, courage, and care for others.

May this story encourage every reader to ask questions, value history, learn from the past, and have the courage to seek what is right.

Remember:

«“A crown may rest upon a head, but leadership must rest upon the heart.”»

— The End —